

# 9 Best Hidden Gems In Europe

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Named Travel Influencer of the Year in 2022

If I can recommend you skip the obvious and visit a lesser-known destination, it'll help disperse the crowds, support communities in other areas and improve tourism around the world. Well, that's the dream!

After several years of extensive travel around Europe, I've come up with a pretty comprehensive list of options for you. Beautiful places, great suggestions for road trips and day trips and a mix of beaches, mountains, lakes, villages, towns and cities. There really is something for everyone in here!

## Terme Di Comano, Trentino, Italy

The area of [Terme di Comano](#) in northern Italy is famed for its healing thermal waters, which are rich in minerals and known to relieve skin disorders and allergies.

It's a beautiful area of Trentino, filled with epic mountains, bright green and blue lakes and a wonderfully hearty cuisine.

It's a completely different destination from summer to winter, as hiking and cycling are replaced with winter sports. I'd recommend late spring or early autumn as lovely times to visit if you want to experience the region's nature at its best. During my trip at the start of October we enjoyed warm sunshine, blue skies and fresh mountain air.

Highlights in Comano include the sentiero della ciuiga hike – a 7.5km route which starts in San Lorenzo and takes you through the region's prettiest villages and out to some stunning remote scenery.

Lake Molveno is also a stunning place to see for yourself. Its rich blue waters draw you in, while the backdrop of the epic Brenta Dolomites is guaranteed to make you feel tiny. It's a special part of Italy, that's for sure, and you should definitely include it in your [European tour](#)!

## **Aeolian Islands, Italy**

While everyone knows Sicily, many haven't heard of the archipelago to its north known as the Aeolian Islands. I was lucky enough to go on a [sailing trip](#) here, stopping at different islands each day. It's a stunning region, and seeing it from the deck of a boat was just perfect.

Our route took us to 6 of the Aeolian Islands – Vulcano, Isola Filicudi, Salina, Stromboli, Panarea, and Lipari. Each one is different and offers specific activities. There's Salina with its beautiful colourful buildings and lush vineyards, epic volcano Stromboli – complete with lava eruptions, and Panarea – the poshest of the islands, known for smart restaurants and a yachting elite!

It's rare to spend time relaxing amongst such fiercely active volcanoes (remember there's Etna on mainland Sicily too!) but it really was a wonderful trip. If you fancy visiting, I'd recommend the hike up Stromboli. The steepness was challenging at times, but seeing a lava eruption with my own eyes is something I'll never forget.

## **Vietri Sul Mare, Italy**

If you thought the Amalfi Coast was all about extortionately priced restaurants and luxury villas, you might be in for a surprise. We discovered the small town of Vietri Sul Mare by chance on holiday a few summers ago, and due to some last minute changes we ended up spending a night there

It's the first town you'll reach from Salerno at the opposite end of the Amalfi Coast from Positano, but it's still absolutely stunning. It's also a LOT cheaper, so perfect for those on a budget.

We stayed at [Hotel La Lucertola](#) – a dated but decent enough hotel right on the water. It was very reasonable for the region and our room had the most mesmerising sea views! I still remember opening the curtains and looking out – wow! From the hotel it was just a short walk to the beach, restaurants and the heart of the action.

The town has the Amalfi Coast vibes without the hefty price tag. Houses and hotels are stacked up on the edge of the mountainous scenery, the beach umbrellas are laid out in perfect lines and the restaurants are lit by candles and full of romance.

## **Rovinj, Croatia**

No doubt you've heard of Dubrovnik and Split... you probably know that Zagreb is the capital. But, have you ever heard of Rovinj? It's not unknown to tourists and can get busy in the summer months, but not on the scale of Dubrovnik and Split.

Rovinj's old town is located on a peninsula. I loved seeing the brightly coloured buildings, fishing boats and exploring the skinny pedestrianised streets. Surrounding the peninsula are clear turquoise waters, perfect for a dip.



*Rovini, Croatia – a welcome alternative to Split and Dubrovnik*

## **Korčula, Croatia**

I visited Korčula on a sailing trip around Croatia, where we visited lots of [islands](#) including Hvar, Šolta and Vis. Korcula is the sixth largest island in Croatia, but doesn't have the crazy crowds or party scene of tourist favourite [Hvar](#).

I'd recommend a trip to the main town on the island – Korcula Town. There you can soak up the history as you pass 15th Century walls and wander streets of medieval stone buildings.

My favourite spot in Korcula Town was Massimos – a cocktail bar on the top of one of the old fort towers. When you order drinks, they're delivered using the special dumb waiter which hoists them to the top of the ancient tower!

Korcula is also home to quaint villages, pristine beaches and a handful of vineyards. It's a little harder to reach than the likes of Hvar and Vis as it's further from the mainland in Split, but that makes it quieter and even more special.

## **Troodos Mountains, Cyprus**

For Brits, Cyprus is a popular country to visit for a beach holiday. A week tanning, swimming, relaxing and maybe a bit of partying too. However, my trip to the country included none of the above! I've surprised a lot of people when I've recounted tales from my time there.

The Troodos Mountains are located in the centre of Cyprus, with the highest point being Mount Olympus at over 1900m. I'd count this mountain range as one of the best hidden gems in Europe. As well as hiking and cycling in the warmer months, you can actually ski in the Troodos Mountains in winter. Skiing in Cyprus? I know – surprising isn't it!

*Did you know Cyprus had mountains and ski resorts? Definitely one of my fave secret places in Europe!*

One of the highlights was my time at [Casale Panayiotis](#) – a luxury hotel, restaurant and spa in a stunning location in the Troodos Mountains. The area is famous for its natural sulphur-spring water, making it a great place to unwind. The views are seriously special too.

I really enjoyed spending time in Lofou – a mountain village with a traditional way of life and more spectacular views.

## **The Hague, Netherlands**

If you've visited Amsterdam or Rotterdam, it's time to try somewhere new. Have you ever been to The Hague? I had a great trip in the summertime and was amazed by how much it offered. I'd always assumed it was a businessy to visit, being home to the Dutch parliament and the U.N.'s International Court of Justice.

However, what I found was surprising and exciting! I know [The Hague](#) is a big place, so less of a 'hidden gem' but I think it's underrated and often overlooked. I spent several days enjoying the beautiful beaches, buzzy restaurants, beach clubs, boutiques, hipster coffee houses, quirky exhibitions, photogenic streets and historic palaces.

My big reason for recommending The Hague is that it fulfils two sets of criteria. Hop on a bus or a tram in the centre of The Hague and in under thirty minutes you can be on Scheveningen or Kijkduin Beach. Both are wide with soft sand and plenty of cool beach clubs, surf schools, and places to hire sun loungers.

Meanwhile, back in the city centre you'll find streets lined with boutiques and hipster cafes, historic palaces, parliament and galleries. If you want a bit of everything on your trip, it's a great destination.

## **Graz, Austria**

[Graz](#) is a picturesque city in the southern Austrian province of Styria. There's a medieval main square, lots of beautiful architecture, plus a 16th-century clock tower perched on a hill overlooking the city.

It's the second most populated city after [Vienna](#), but it doesn't feel touristy in the slightest. A huge reason to visit? The food! Graz is known as the culinary capital of Austria. The food is quite different to other regions of Austria. Being in the south it benefits from a Mediterranean climate, which is reflected in the fresh produce and cooking techniques.

The city is also an UNESCO World Heritage Site – brimming with history, stunning architecture and museums. It's funny though, while I enjoyed seeing the historic sites, it was the hipster, quirky edge that has remained rooted in my brain. There's a great café scene, some quirky restaurants, modern art and architecture and even a place you can go surfing on the river!

## **Sormland, Sweden**

When you think of Sweden, no doubt you have visions of magical forests, pretty lakes and traditional summerhouses. Of people celebrating midsummer with crayfish and schnapps, and cosy saunas followed by icy lake dips.

Sörmland is exactly this place! It's only an hour and a half from Stockholm, so when the city's residents need a break, this is where they escape to.

During my visit I kayaked through the archipelago, tried my hand at wild cooking, explored stunning forests, took a million photos of serene lakes, visited Gripsholm Castle (a fairytale castle on the banks of Lake Mälaren), warmed up in a sauna and even hung out with some adorable donkeys!

I also hiked a part of the Sörmlandsleden – a hiking trail that starts near Stockholm and stretches for 1,000 km.

